Paraphrasing: synonyms, word forms and voice change

Understand it

IELTS never tests whether you can find the same word; it tests whether you can find the same meaning. Questions and answers are paraphrased with synonyms, different word forms, active / passive changes and new structures.

Learn to see the meaning through the words. When you write, use the same tools to paraphrase the task question.

The rules

- Questions never use the exact words of the text. They paraphrase: increase = rise = go up.
- Change the word form: He decided = his decision; the rapid growth = it grew rapidly.
- Change active and passive: The council built the bridge = The bridge was built by the council.
- Change the structure: Because of the rain, the match stopped = The match stopped due to the rain / as a result of heavy rain.

All the words and forms you need

Synonyms	increase = rise = grow · important = vital = crucial · problem = issue = challenge · help = assist = support
Word form	decide → decision · grow → growth · able → ability · popular → popularity
Active / passive	Scientists discovered X = X was discovered by scientists
Negative / positive	not cheap = expensive · not many = few · not always = sometimes
Structure	because of = due to = as a result of · in order to = so that · it is hard to = finding ... is hard

Where you use it

Reading: Underline key words in the question, then search for synonyms, not the same words.

Listening: The speaker says the correction in different words from the question.

Writing: Paraphrase the question in your introduction.

Speaking: If you forget a word, explain it with another: the thing you use to ...

More examples

- Question: The number of visitors went up. Text: Tourist arrivals rose.

- Question: The study was paid for by the government. Text: The state funded the research.
- Question: Few people use the service. Text: The service is rarely used.
- Question: The method is not new. Text: The technique has existed for decades.

Common mistakes

Wrong	Right
✗ Looking for the exact word of the question.	✓ Look for the same meaning.
✗ Changing only one word and keeping the same structure in writing.	✓ Change the structure too.
✗ Choosing the answer that repeats the question words in Multiple Choice.	✓ Often it is a trap; choose the same meaning.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. Describe your hometown, then describe it again with different words.
2. Explain a word you don't know in English using other words.
3. What do people do to stay healthy? Say it two different ways.

Writing practice

Paraphrase this Task 2 question in two ways: Many people think that the government should spend more money on public transport.

Practice

1. Synonym for rise (verb):

2. Change to a noun: They decided to leave.

3. Change to passive: The government banned plastic bags.

4. Paraphrase: due to the heavy rain

5. Paraphrase: a large number of people

6. Paraphrase: It is difficult to find a job.

Answers

1. increase / go up / grow
2. Their decision to leave
3. Plastic bags were banned by the government.
4. because of / as a result of the heavy rain
5. many people / a great many people
6. Finding a job is hard.